

Reminder: No electronics during class

Storytelling and Narratives in Business (BUSN 42124)

Prof. Guy Rolnik



What's the story here?

Office Hours Full

Please attend only one session (group or individual) and remove your name from the spreadsheet so others can join.

Show of hands:
Who likes CONFLICT?

Session 3:

There's no story without conflict

Yesterday, on Storytelling and Narratives in Business

- Our brains are wired for story
 - Transportation
 - Stories are simulators for life – and a Trojan horse
- Purpose
 - What you want the audience to Think, feel, do
- Audience
 - WIIFT
 - Beliefs
- Controlling Idea
 - The primary message
 - Value + Message

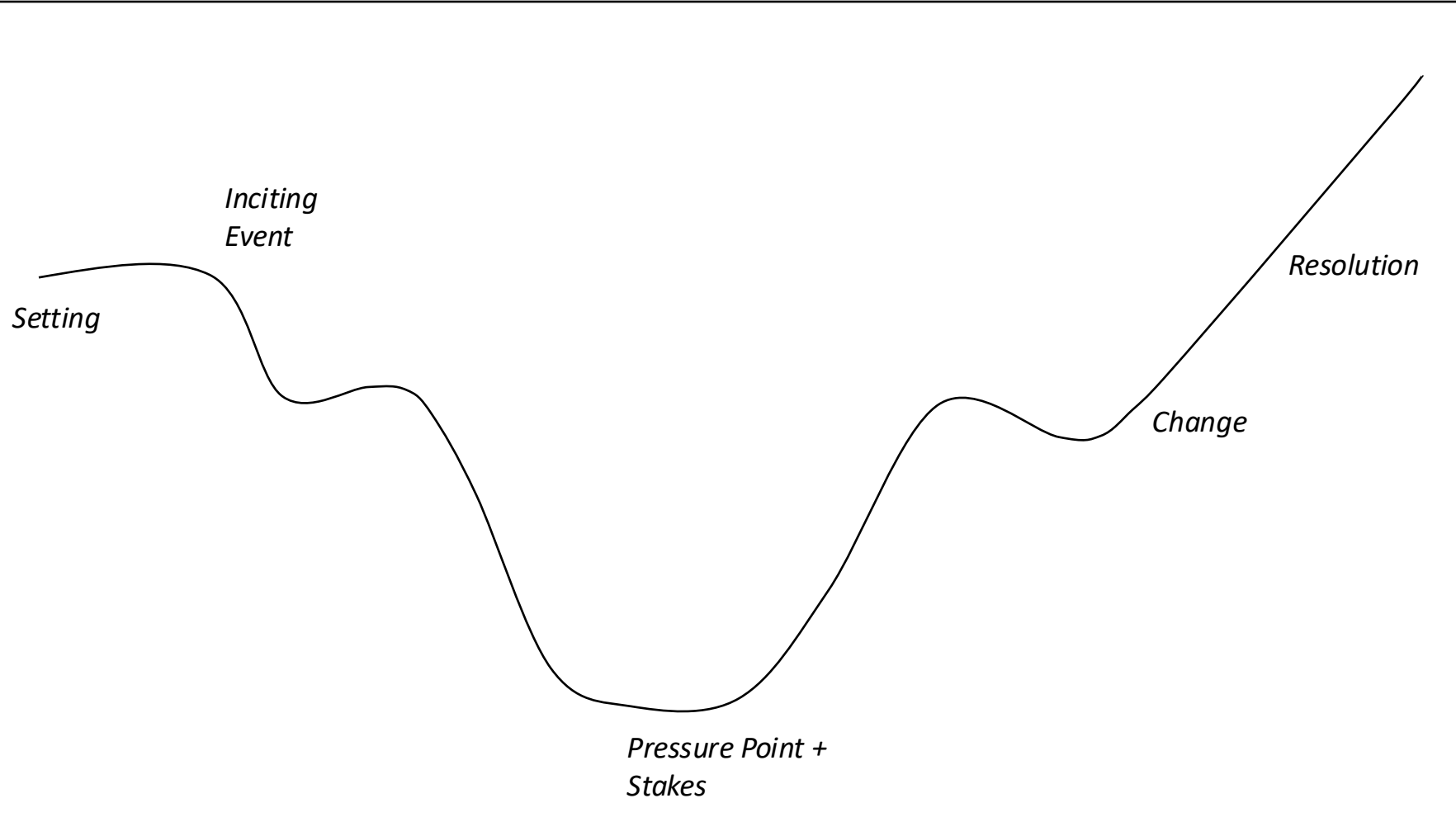
Story Headline

Purpose: WIIFM?

The Audience
Who are they?
WIIFT?
Beliefs

Controlling Idea

Protagonist
Antagonist
Conflict



Creative techniques

- ☐ Limitations
- ☐ Details, facts, anecdotes
- ☐ Mystery Box
- ☐ Metaphors
- ☐ Cultural references
- ☐ Simplicity
- ☐ Show, don't tell
- ☐ Interact

TAKE IT WITH YOU

Purpose

- What are you “selling”? (An idea? A product? Yourself?)
- What do you want your audience to Feel? Think? Do?

Audience

- To whom are you telling your story?
- What are their beliefs in regards to your controlling idea?
- What’s in it for them (why should they care)?

Controlling Idea

- What message are you communicating in order to achieve your purpose? Value + Message
- What is the universal value? What are you saying about that value?

Tips:

- Use universal values: life/death, love/hate, freedom/slavery, truth/lie, courage/cowardice, loyalty/betrayal, wisdom/stupidity, strength/weakness, hope/despair...
- Use a common template: X happens because the hero does Y; If you want to do X, you have to do Y; With X comes Y; There’s no X without Y, etc.

Session 3 plot

- The Protagonist
- Nemesis and Conflict
- Story structure:
 - Setting
 - Inciting Event
 - Pressure point and Stakes
 - The Resolution
 - The Change

The Protagonist

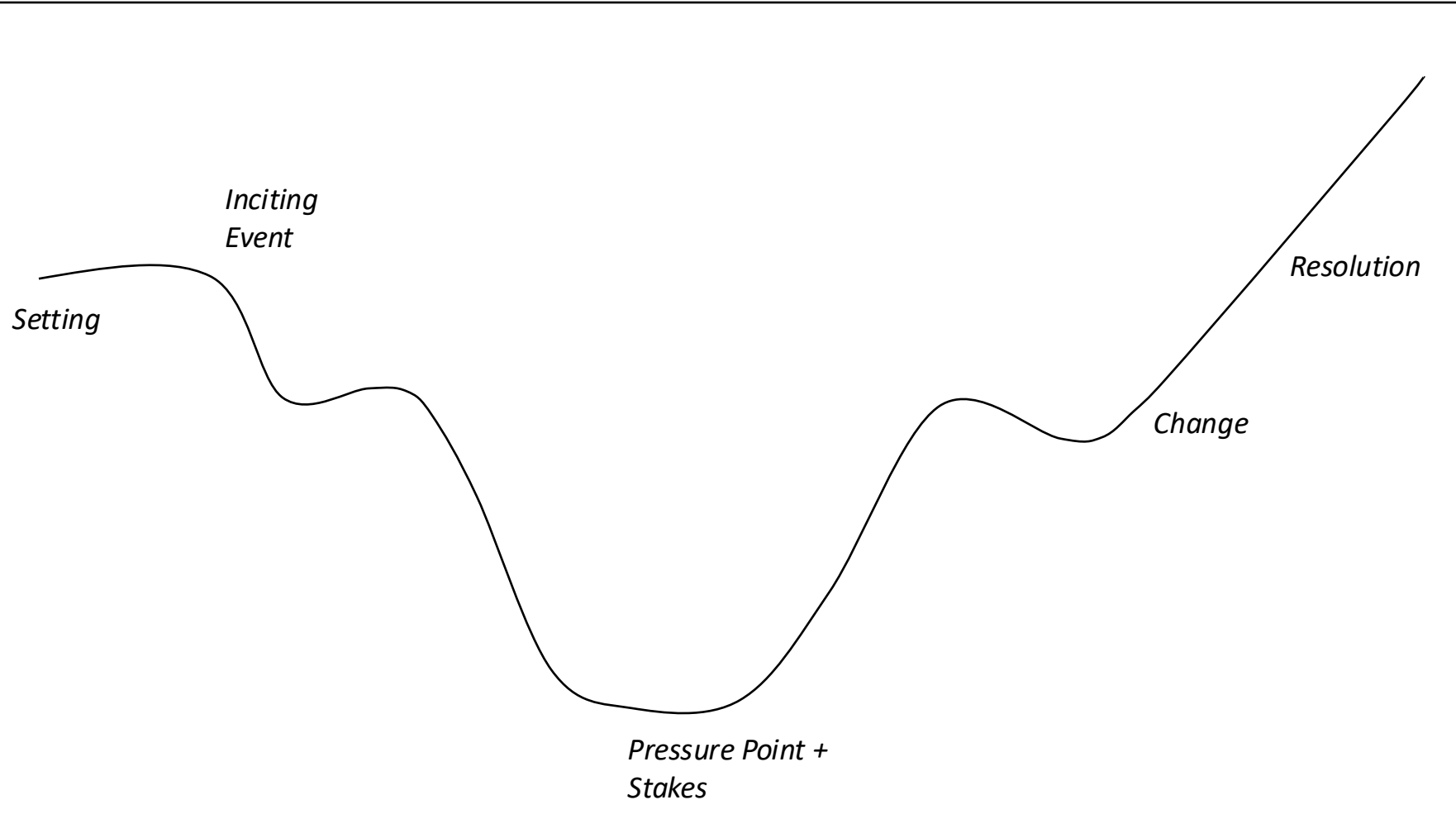
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What is a protagonist?

- The principal character in a literary work (such as a drama or story)
- The leading actor or principal character in a television show, movie, book, etc.

→ The Hero

Why do we need a Hero?

The 5 reasons a story needs a Hero

- A hero **connects** us to the story
- A hero makes a story **familiar** to us
- A hero provides us with someone **to root for** and to **identify** with
- ...and thus, help us be **transported**
- Through the hero and his/her conflict, we **learn about life and about ourselves**

The Protagonist's Goal

- A protagonist without a **clear goal** has nothing to figure out and nowhere to go
- The story isn't about whether or not the protagonist achieves his/her goal – it's about what he/she has to overcome internally to do it – it's about **the change** he/she has to undergo
- What the protagonist is forced **to learn** as he/she navigates the plot is what the story is about (i.e., the Controlling Idea)

The Protagonist's characteristics

- A protagonist has a **conscious desire**
- A protagonist may also have an **unconscious desire**
- The most memorable, fascinating characters have both
- The protagonist must arouse our **empathy** – the audience must feel that in some way he/she are like them
- The protagonist may or may not earn our **sympathy** (=likability) – the audience does not have to like them, but they must be able to identify with their journey

The Hero's Unconscious desire
should be a common, universal
emotion that we – the audience –
often feel ourselves

Quiz: What do they want?

See if you know what the following protagonists want –
both their external and internal goals





Superheroes: the simplified formula*

Superhero	External desire	Internal desire
Spiderman	Fight villains	Overcome remorse (death of uncle)

Can you think of examples
from your experience
in the business world –
of conscious and unconscious
desires of protagonists?

In order to care about a protagonist,
you have to understand **the stakes**:
what he or she is risking,
what sacrifices they might have to
make to achieve their goal –
and what will happen if they fail

In marketing, the Hero
is not necessarily you. It could be
your customer/client/consumer

But, a protagonist
is not enough

Conflict

The Law of Conflict

Nothing moves forward in a story,
except through conflict.
The conflict is the soul of the story.

Problem and solution

(I had a problem and I figured it out) =
boring/ok story.

Much better:

Problem → **Conflict** → Solution

Types of conflict: What is keeping the protagonist from achieving his or her desire?

- Person vs. Himself
 - Internal conflicts: doubt, fear, confusion, lack of confidence...
- Person vs. Person
 - Personal conflicts: With friends, family, lovers, colleagues, bosses...
- Person vs. Nature
 - Physical conflicts: Mother Nature and its forces, time, disease...
- Person vs. Society
 - Social conflicts: norms, groups, other companies, the government...
- Person vs. Supernatural
- Person vs. Destiny

Here are a few real-life examples

- Person vs. Himself
 - A businessman who inherited his father's holding company, struggling to build his own self-esteem
- Person vs. Person
 - Two law firms merging, with partners fighting for control
- Person vs. Nature
 - A freelance wedding photographer, frustrated with the length of time demanded by editing
- Person vs. Society
 - A renewable energy company, trying to cope with changing political priorities
 - A food delivery company, challenging a dominant competitor
 - A crypto startup, trying to persuade regulators

A protagonist and his/her story
can only be as intellectually fascinating
and emotionally compelling
as the forces of antagonism make them

The “best” conflicts
tie back to the controlling idea

Let's look at a few examples

What is the conflict in the following ads?



Examples of business world conflicts



Confronting your boss (e.g., asking for a raise)



Competing with colleagues/classmates for a job



Juggling work/family commitments



Interacting with customers



Interacting with regulators



Handling a media crisis



Internal conflict (Do I really want this job? Do I simply want to make my parents proud? Am I good enough for the position?)



Let's look at some companies

What conflicts are these companies tackling?













Remember:

You do not want to tell a beginning-to-end tale describing how results met expectations.

This is boring and banal.

Instead, you want to display the struggle between expectation and reality in all its nastiness.

Here's an example

I'd like to raise money
from VCs and PE investors
for a start-up
developing a new drug

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I can show
a lot of graphs

e.g.,

Market size

Business plan

Org chart

Chemical properties

Competitive analysis

I can show
a lot of graphs

e.g.,

Market size

Business plan

Org chart

Chemical properties

Competitive analysis

or

I can
tell a story

e.g.,

A father's death

A protein's discovery

An FDA battle

A partner leaving

A patent race...

So, why should you come to VCs with a story?

Why should you come to VCs with a story?

- Because VCs often invest in a person more than they invest in a company
- ...because they know that, in any case, you'll pivot and/or change the business model more than once before you find product/market fit
- Because a story allows them to learn about your character, and about your ability to overcome obstacles and challenges
- Because anyone can show graphs, but not everyone can tell an authentic story
- Because a story establishes trust, and can (potentially) create connection

BREAK

What if you need to tell a story, but there isn't enough time or space?

How to tell a story in ~280 characters

Social media's greatest storyteller

Let's look at examples

No politics, please



Conflict

6.4k Likes

Mar 13, 2025, 5:28 PM



Conflict

~~60.5k~~ Likes

Mar 04, 2025, 5:30 AM



....The United States has a vested interest in the secure, efficient, and reliable operation of the Panama Canal, and that was well understood. We would not want to get involved into the wrong side of the conflict.

Conflict

Continued

...ama. If the
...ar and legal, of this
...ous gesture of giving are not
...ollowed, then we will demand that the Panama
Canal be returned to us, in full, and without
question. To the Officials of Panama, please be
guided accordingly!

1.86k ReTruths **5.95k** Likes

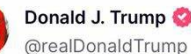
Dec 21, 2024 at 5:16 PM



The Golden Age of America has just begun! Over the past weeks, our Administration has delivered more than any Administration before it, always with a focus on the people. It has been an incredible journey, and we are just getting started. In this place, I have seen the best of our people. We have a leadership to work with, and a Staffing. As the people understand, the people working for the Administration, they can be very precise as to who will stay and who will go. We say the "scalpel" rather than the "machet." The combination of them, Elon, DOGE, and other great people will be able to do things at a historic level.



Conflict



After speaking with President Claudia Sheinbaum of Mexico, I have agreed that Mexico will be required to pay Tariffs on any goods that violate the USMCA Agreement. I signed the agreement on April 2nd, 2024. I am proud of this agreement. It is a good one, and we are working together to stop illegal aliens from entering the United States and, likewise, stopping Fentanyl. Thank you to President Sheinbaum for your hard work and cooperation!



I have had many talks with China about the massive
drugs, in particular Fentanyl, being sent into the United States.
But to no avail. Representatives of the Chinese government
institute their maximum efforts to keep their drug dealers
caught doing their business. The Chinese government has
and has not allowed drugs to flow through, at
least not mostly through Mexico, at
least not as much as they stop, we will be
charging a national 10% Tariff, above any additional
Tariffs for their many products coming into the United States
of America. Thank you for your attention to this matter.

3.35k ReTruths 12.2k Likes

Nov 26, 2024, 5:05 AM



To the Great Farmers of the United States, Tariffs making a lot of agricultural products. Have fun!

41

Mar 03, 2025, 1:32 PM



I'm asking companies not to let TikTok stay dark! I will issue an executive order on Monday to extend the period of time before the law's prohibitions take effect, so that we can make a deal to protect our national security. The order will also confirm that there will be no liability for any company that helped keep TikTok going dark before my order.

Americans deserve to
well as other

...ownership position in
...we save TikTok, keep it in good
...pay up. Without U.S. approval, there is no Tik
...approval, it is worth hundreds of billions of dollars -
...trillions.

Therefore, my initial thought is a joint venture between the current owners and/or new owners whereby the U.S. gets a 50% ownership in a joint venture set up between the U.S. and whichever purchase we so choose.

4.52k ReTruths 17.6k Likes

Jan 19, 2025 at 10:00 AM

What makes Trump such a great storyteller on social media?

What makes Trump such a great storyteller on social media?

Many of his posts include all of a story's important elements

- Purpose
- Audience
- Controlling idea
- Protagonist
- Antagonist
- Conflict

The protagonist:
Trump. Fighting
the war on drugs.

The audience:
Trump's base. They suffer
from the spread of Fentanyl.



Justin Trudeau, of Canada, called me to ask what could be done about Tariffs. I told him that many people have died from Fentanyl that came through the Borders of Canada and Mexico, and nothing has convinced me that it has stopped. He said that it's gotten better, but I said, "That's not good enough." The call ended in a "somewhat" friendly manner! He was unable to tell me when the Canadian Election is taking place, which made me curious, like, what's going on here? I then realized he is trying to use this issue to stay in power. Good luck Justin!

12.4k ReTruths 56.9k Likes

The antagonist:
Canada.

The conflict:
Trump vs. Trudeau.
Taking responsibility

Controlling idea:
America will prevail
because Trump will
cut the bull****.

The purpose: Portray Canada as
a culprit in the drug crisis. The
audience should think that
Trump is the one fix things.

Let's summarize

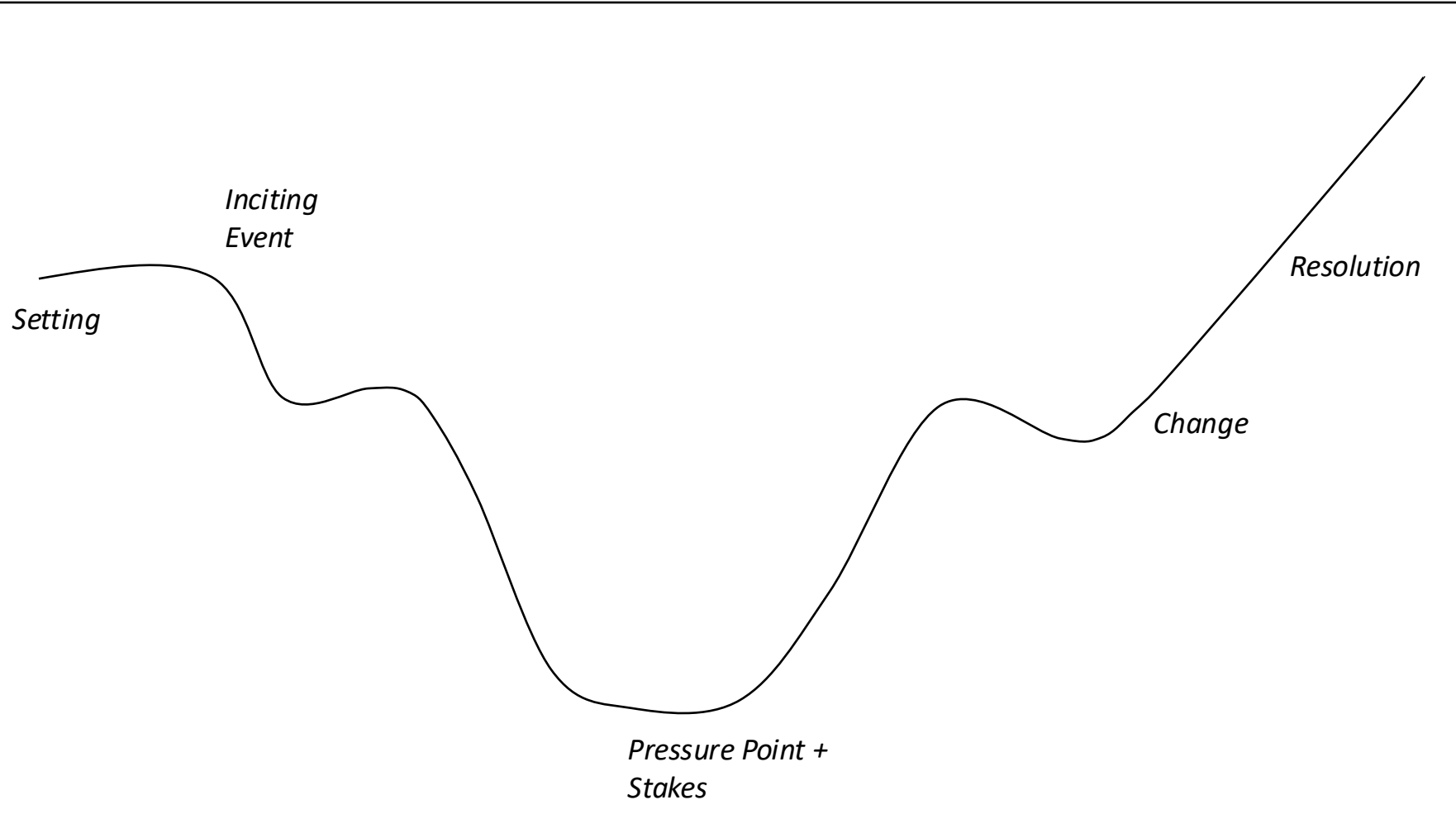
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Summary

- The Protagonist
 - Conscious and unconscious desire
 - Earns empathy, not necessarily sympathy
- Conflict
 - The soul of the story
 - Problem → **Conflict** → Solution
 - Solution = The Controlling Idea
 - Types of conflict (see Take it with you)

TAKE IT WITH YOU

Protagonist

- Who is your Hero?
- What is the Hero's conscious desire?
- What is the Hero's **un**conscious desire?
- Does the Hero earn our empathy? Are we, in some way, similar to that person?
(tip: think of the universal value in your Controlling Idea)

Conflict

- The soul of the story and the engine of its plot
- Problem → Solution is not enough! Make sure: Problem → **Conflict** → Solution
- Is your solution tied to the Controlling Idea?

Types of conflict: Person vs. Himself (doubt, fear, confusion, uncertainty...); Person vs. Person (lovers, family, friends, peers, bosses, other people...); Person vs. Nature (weather, animals, disease, time, distance...); Person vs. Society (companies, institutions, governments, groups, norms...); Person vs. Supernatural; Person vs. Destiny.

Story structure

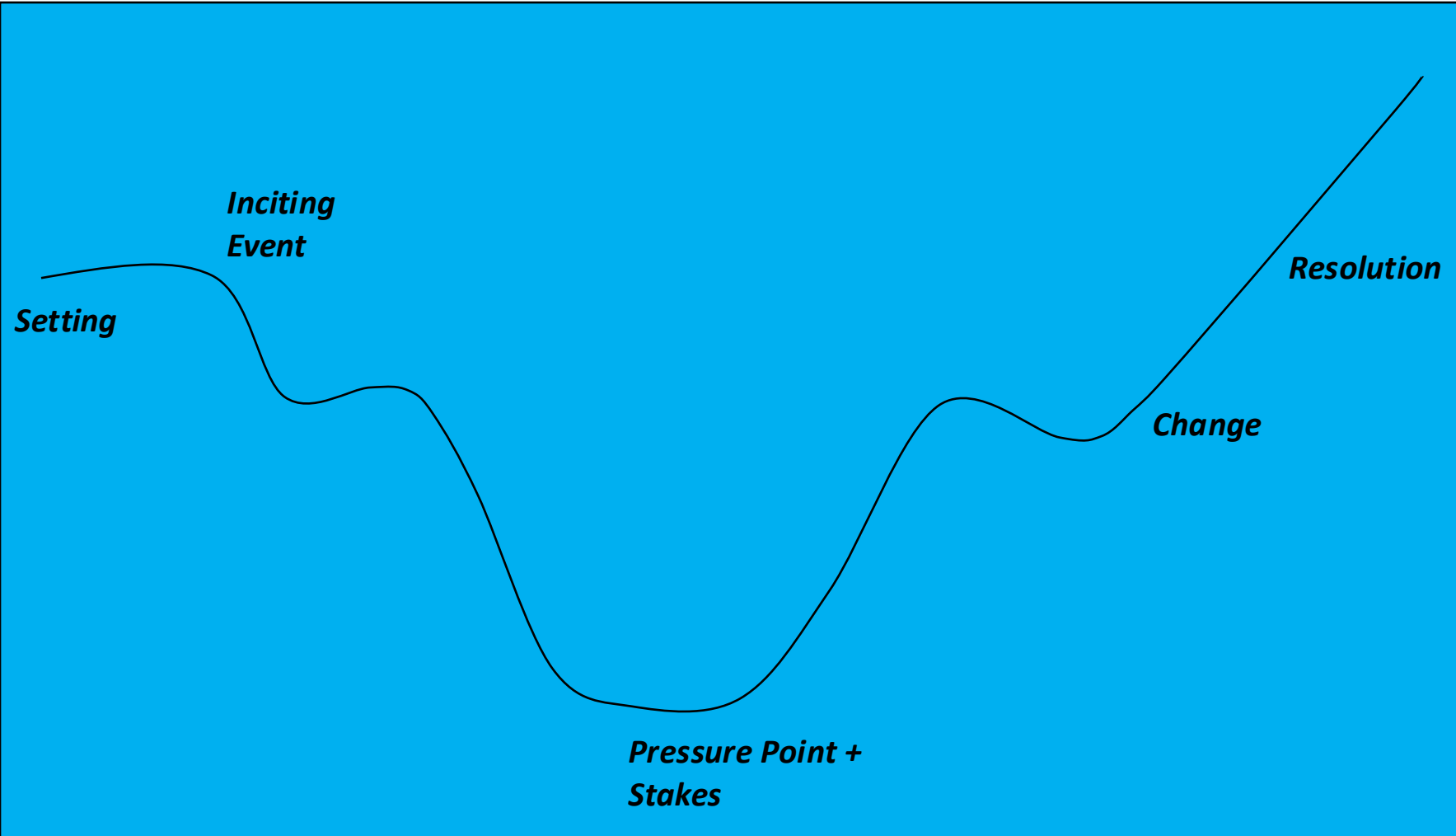
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The Setting

The setting

- Period: A story's place in time
- Duration: A story's length through time
 - One hour? One day? A decade?
- Location: Where the story takes place

Enriching the setting

Based on relevance to your story, answer such questions as:

- What is **the backstory**? i.e., the set of significant events in the character's past pertaining to the protagonist's quest
- Is there **a cast of characters** the audience should know?
- What are **the politics** of my world (the distribution of power)?
- What are **the values** in my world? What is right/wrong, good/evil?
- What are **the rituals** of my world?

The importance of setting

The better we understand the story's setting –
and the more we know about the protagonist's background –
the better we understand **the Stakes** for the protagonist
when he encounters Conflict and gets to the Pressure Point.





INTERNS

THIS SPRING

Please help us welcome Lamont Morehead
(Miles College) & Markaylee Talton (Shelton
State Community College)!

 innovation depot





The Inciting Event



Succession

75 Emmy nominations for Outstanding Drama Series, 19 wins



What role do the opening credits play?
What do we learn watching them?

Present the (relevant) cast

Provide details about the characters surrounding the protagonist – details that will help the listeners understand the context for your story and, especially, the conflict and the stakes.

Relevant details might be:

- How are they related to the protagonist?
- What is their status vis-à-vis the hero?
- What is their demeanor and attitude?
- How do they speak?
- How would you describe their physical appearance? (How old are they? What are they wearing? etc.)

e.g., if the story is about your boss – it would help to know what kind of boss he or she is.

A few key details can make all the difference.

The Inciting Event

The Inciting Event

The Inciting Event upsets the balance in the protagonist's life – and **introduces complication** into the story.

In other words, the Inciting Event puts the plot into motion.

The hero thinks he or she can tackle
or solve the complication.
When they fail to do so,
the Conflict of the story is revealed.

Returning to our Superheroes...

Superhero	External desire	Internal desire
Spiderman	Fight villains	Overcome remorse (death of uncle)
Iron Man	Fame and adoration	His father's love
Hulk	Smash	Control rage
Captain America	Fight evil	Inferiority complex
Thor	Rule the Nine realms like his father	Become a worthy leader
Captain Marvel	Protect the galaxy	Discover her own identity
Thanos	The six Infinity Stones	Balance in the universe

The Inciting Event in Pixar's 7-step process

1. Once there was a _____ [a protagonist/hero with a goal]
2. Every day he _____ [at the beginning, there is balance]
- 3. Until one day _____ [complication is introduced]**
4. Because of that _____ [the hero is compelled to act]
5. Because of that _____ [the chain of events continues]
6. Until finally _____ [the climax reveals the triumph of good over evil]
7. Ever since then _____ [the moral of the story]

1. Once upon a time...



5. Because of that...



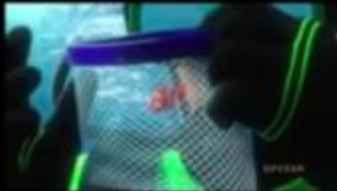
2. Every day...



6. Because of that...



3. Until one day...



7. Until finally...



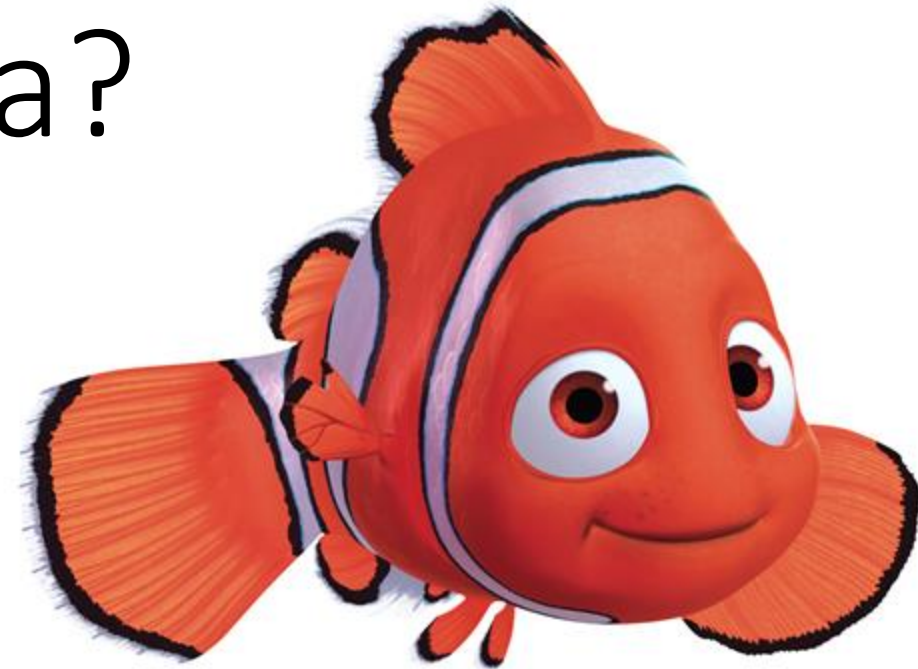
4. Because of this...



8. Ever since then...



Finding Nemo's controlling idea?



Parents need to let go in order
for their kids to grow up

Can you think of examples
for Inciting Events
in a business context,
from your own experience?

Inciting Event examples

- Fired from job, career change requires starting from the bottom
- Failure to earn employee buy-in threatens project success
- Negative internship experience sheds doubt on career choice
- Coworker harassment precipitates job change
- Fatal workplace accident arouses guilt, redefines safety management philosophy

The Pressure Point and the Stakes

The Pressure Point

Any story builds to a climax,
which brings the conflict of the story to a head.

Will the hero overcome him/herself?

Will good triumph over evil?

The Pressure Point is the
lowest point in the Story's Arc –
and when the Stakes for the Hero
are highest

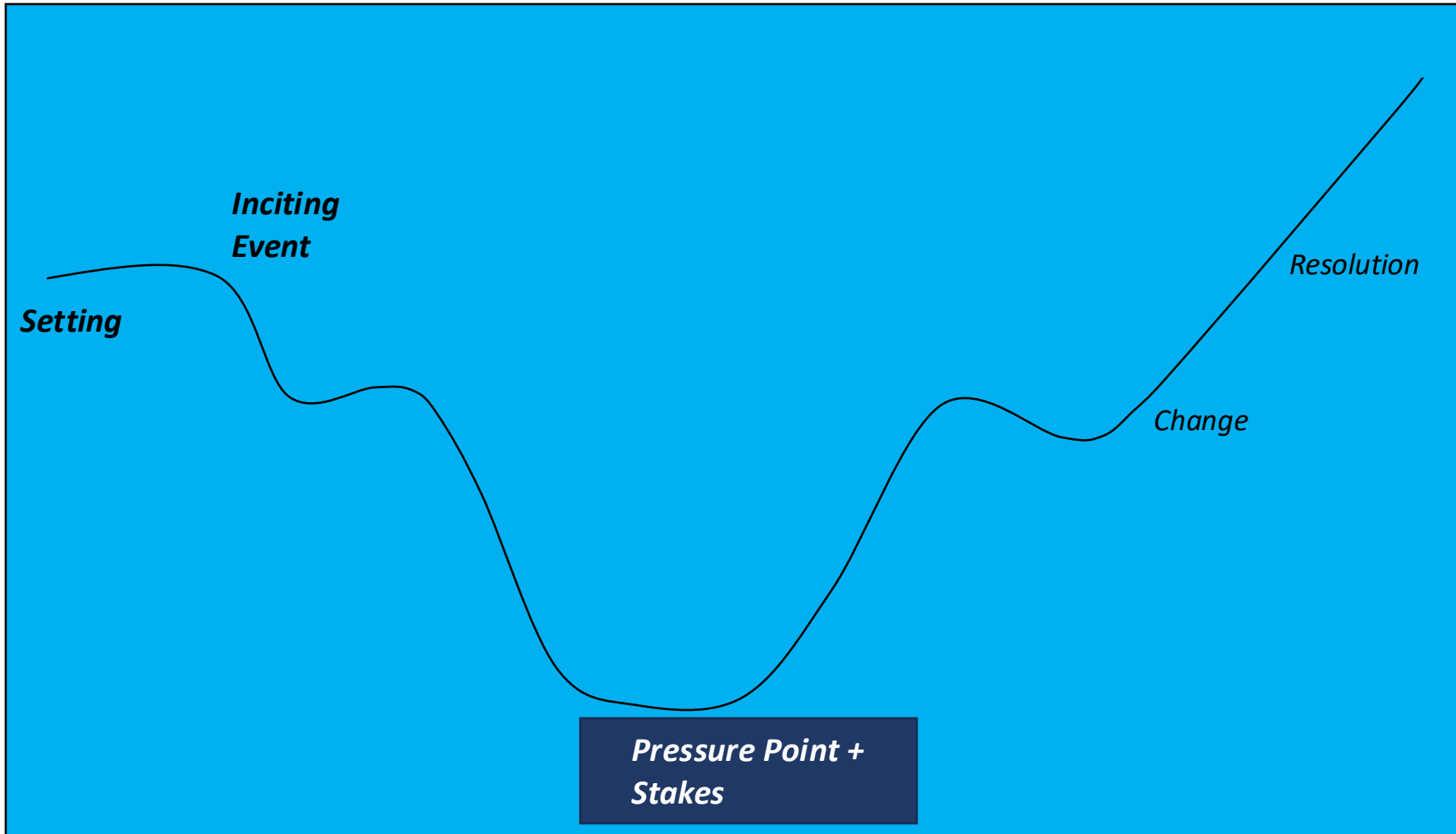
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The meanings of “Stake”

- Originally, as stake was a wooden or metal post with a point at one end, driven into the ground as a boundary marker or as a support
 - It was also used as a post to which a person was bound for execution by burning
- In modern times, a stake is something (e.g., sum of money) that is invested or wagered – and, in a sense, risked – for gain or loss: the prize in a contest, or a share in an enterprise
- To **raise the stakes** (or to up the stakes) is to increase the potential gain or loss – and, by implication, make a situation more risky or difficult to tackle

In our context,
the Stakes are the risk the Hero is facing
at the most pressure-filled moment
of the story

To define the Stakes, you need to ask yourself...

- What are you risking?
- What do you stand to lose, or to gain?
- How much does it matter to you?
- What will happen if your desire remains unfulfilled?
What will the consequences be?

The Stakes can be both Internal (emotional and/or psychological) – or external (literally, what might happen in the world outside if the hero succeeds or fails)

The Stakes don't have to be true or real in an objective sense (failing an exam, or being unsuccessful in a job interview don't really undermine our entire future). They convey the Hero's **feeling** that he or she are making a fateful decision.

The Stakes are inextricably linked to the story's Controlling Idea

The Stakes revolve around the universal human Value that drives the story. Thus, they often reveal the story's theme – its Controlling Idea.

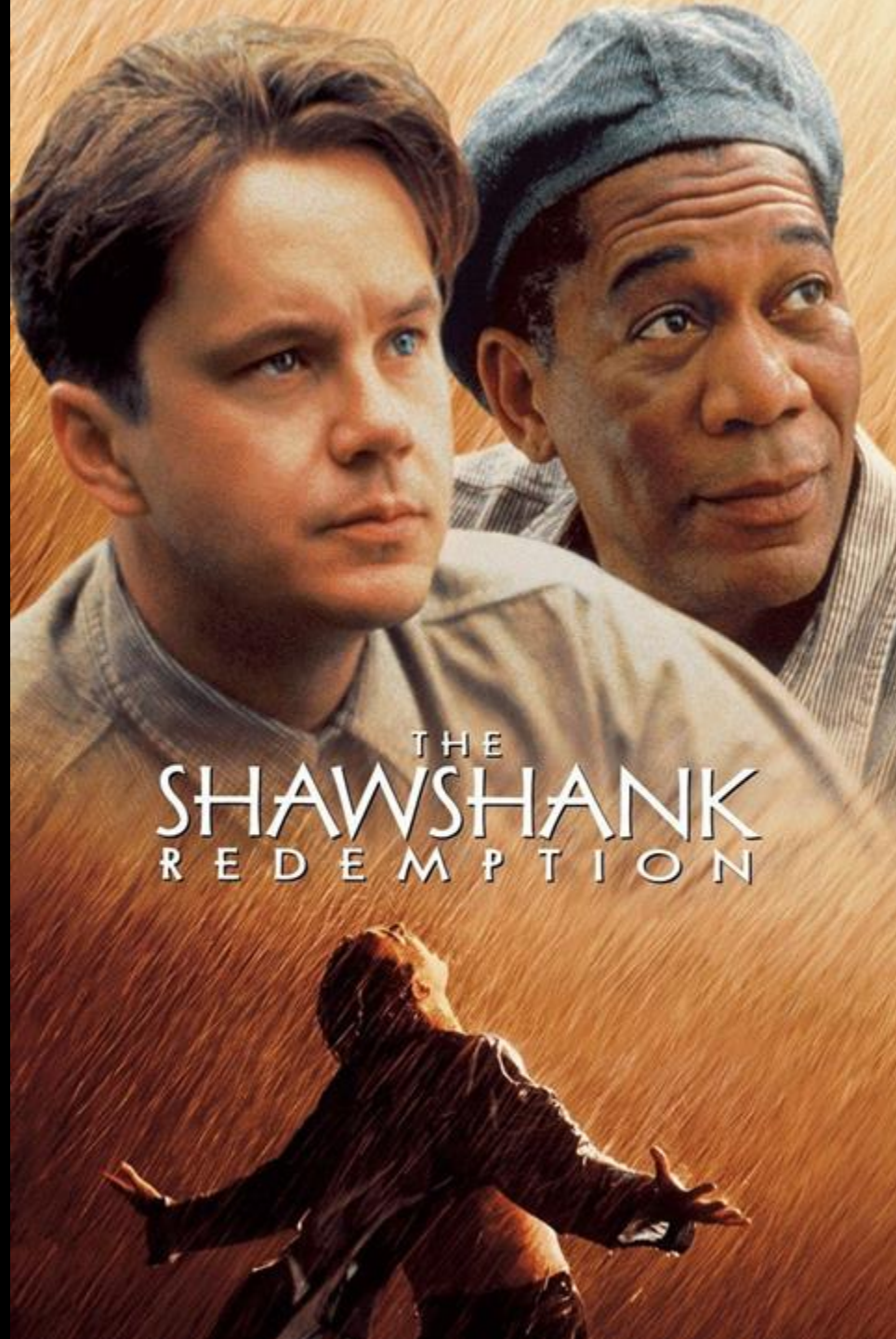
Here are a few famous examples

[Warning: some spoilers ahead, as well as some cursing]



JAWS













Pressure point Forces Critical Choices:

- Pushes the protagonist to face the most intense internal or external pressure.
- Characters are compelled to make crucial decisions, revealing their deepest nature and values.
- Often involves significant risk or sacrifice, thus highlighting the protagonist's identity.

Pressure point Forces Critical Choices:

- True character is revealed in the choices a human being makes under pressure.
- The greater the pressure, the deeper the revelation, the truer the choice to the character's essential nature.

Pressure point Catalyzing Transformation:

- The low point sets the stage for meaningful change or transformation within the protagonist.
- It's here that the character realizes the flaws in their previous approach or worldview.
- Without this intense pressure, a deep personal transformation or growth would be less believable or satisfying.

Pressure point Amplifying Emotional Engagement:

- The pressure point heightens audience empathy and emotional involvement.
- Viewers or readers feel more connected when protagonists endure hardship and grapple with genuine, relatable struggles.
- The vulnerability displayed at this juncture fosters emotional investment, making the subsequent resolution all the more impactful.

Pressure point

Providing Dramatic Structure:

- Pressure point provides narrative tension, ensuring the story maintains momentum.
- It acts as the key turning point, moving the story from complications and rising tension to a decisive climax and eventual resolution.

Pressure point

Clarifying Stakes and Meaning:

- The intense pressure of the low point clarifies what's truly at stake.
- It also emphasizes the cost of failure, making the final resolution or climax significantly more meaningful.

Why is the pressure point critical?

- It forces authentic character decision
- It drives believable transformation
- It heightens emotional connection
- It structures dramatic tension
- It clarifies what's ultimately at stake for the protagonist

BREAK

How do we raise the Stakes?

How do we make it matter not only for our Hero –
but also for the audience?

How do we make the story as powerful and as gripping as possible?

1. Define the Dilemma

Choices have consequences. A dilemma is a **difficult** choice –
a trade-off between two evils, or between two blessings
(if it's between good and bad, it's not really a difficult choice)

Remember: A Dilemma SHOULD be difficult

- A Dilemma is a situation in which our protagonist faces two or more equally desirable or undesirable options, each with significant consequences
- In a Dilemma, there is **no clear “right” choice** – the hero must navigate conflicting priorities, values, or loyalties
- If the choice is easy, there’s no Dilemma
- Equally, if one of the choices is morally or ethically superior – there is no Dilemma
- If the **consequences** of the protagonist’s choice are not meaningful, it again means that the Dilemma was not that difficult

2. Remember the Setting

Plant pertinent details when you set up the story – so the audience knows what's important to you from the very beginning.

(Sometimes you can up the ante by starting with the Pressure Point – and then going back to the setting).

3. Change the pace

Slow down key moments (and when approaching key moments) by diving into details [see next tip].

Use short sentences to heighten the tension or the excitement.

Speed through the less-important parts (as Elaine from Seinfeld once said: “yadda yadda yadda”).

4. Zoom in with details

A few, very specific (but relevant) details can go a long way in transporting the audience.

For example, delight the senses (describe sounds and smells); recite dialogue; describe personas and their environments; reveal emotions.

5. Add a time limit

There's nothing like a deadline to add suspense...

6. Make it personal for the nemesis

Make the Pressure Point matter to your nemesis, as well (even if not for the same reason).

7. Make it bigger

Sharpen the costs of failure – or boost the reward
(but stay true to what's happened).

8. Break the 4th wall

Share your emotions –
let the audience know how you feel in the story's biggest moments.

How to raise the Stakes

1. Define the Dilemma
2. Remember the Setting
3. Change the pace
4. Zoom in with details
5. Add a time limit
6. Make it personal for the nemesis
7. Make it bigger
8. Break the 4th wall

The Resolution – and the Change

Resolution

The closing moments must be gratifying and meaningful, in order **to bring the story to its logical resolution and closure.**

Ask yourself: **How is the Conflict resolved?**

The Resolution and the Change

As part of the Resolution (leading to it, or as a result of it) the Protagonist **changes**.

Ask yourself: **What change has the protagonist undergone?**

Beliefs and traits (=who you become)
are elements of Change.
In either case, the change should be
demonstrated through **actions**.

So, when it comes to your story, ask yourself:

- What lesson did I learn?
- What did I discover about myself?
- How did my **behavior change** from that point on?

Through your **actions**, the audience
will know you've changed – and how

Finally, ask yourself:
Does the resolution **convey** the lesson –
i.e., **the Controlling Idea**?

Change examples in a business context

- I've realized that in order for me to shine, I actually have to learn how to become part of the team
- I learned that I don't know how to accept criticism. I practiced opening myself up for feedback
- I now understand what it means to take responsibility for your actions. I know that next time I will accept the consequences
- I've learned that despite my background in the Marines, leading a team is about finding motivations as opposed to giving orders

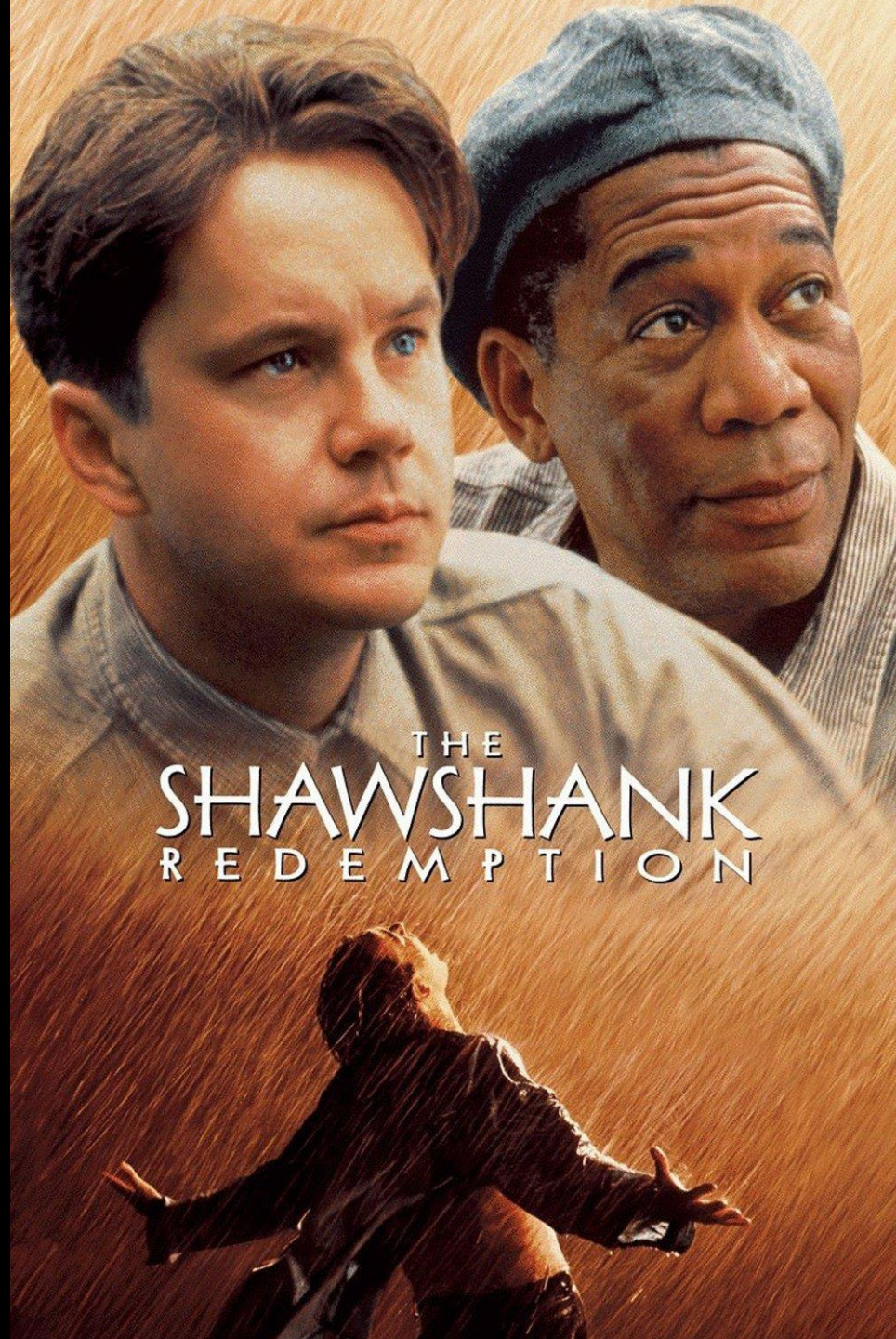
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JAWS





THE
SHAWSHANK
REDEMPTION











Let's summarize

Session summary

- The Setting
 - Period, duration, location, adjacent characters
- The Inciting Event
 - Introduce a complication
- The Pressure Point and The Stakes
 - The lowest Arc point – and the highest Stakes
 - Tying the Stakes back to the Controlling Idea
 - How to raise the Stakes
- Change
 - How did the Protagonist change?
 - Demonstrate through **action**
- Resolution
 - How was the Conflict resolved? Did it convey the Controlling Idea?

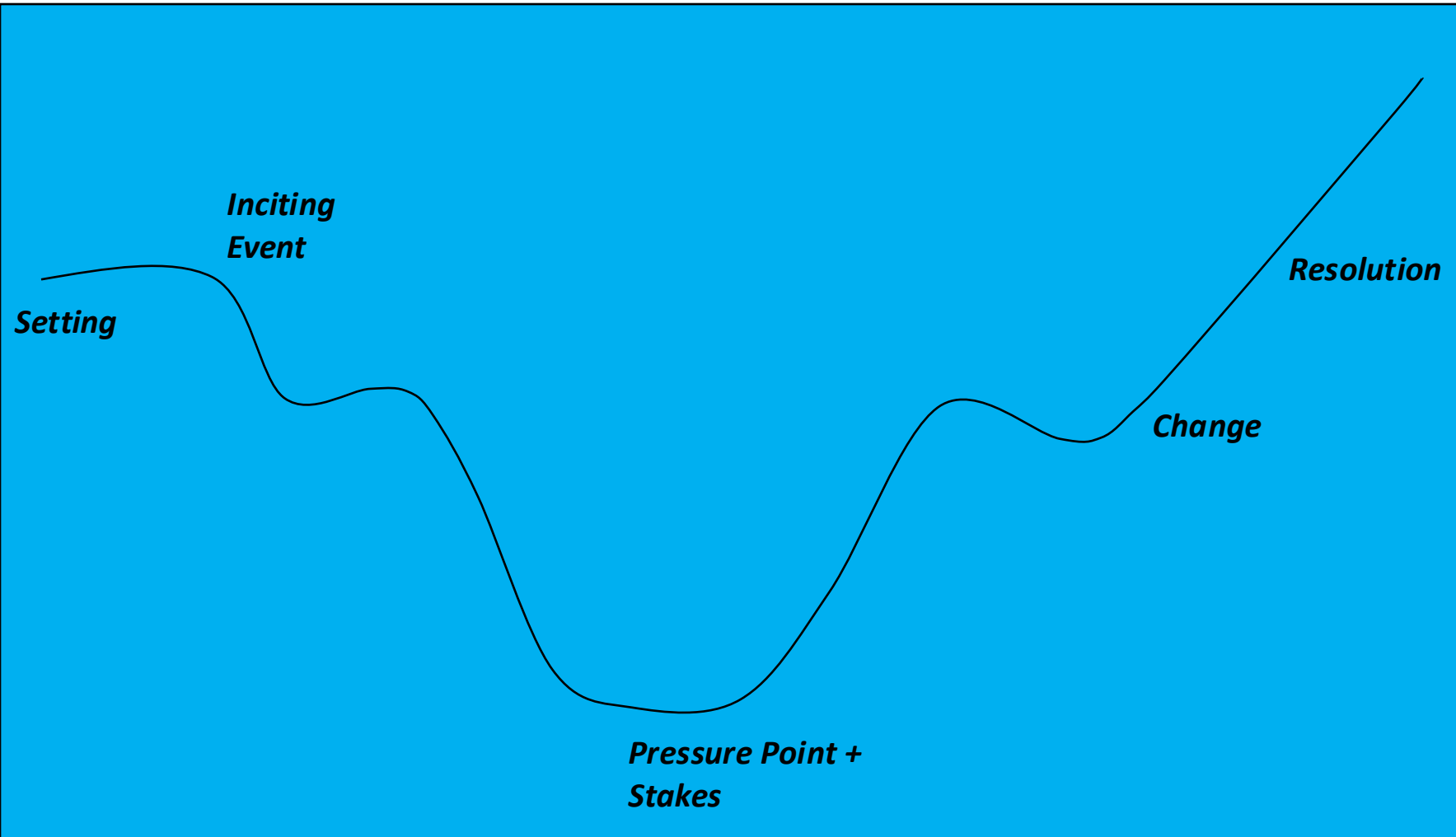
Story Headline

Purpose: WIIFM?

The Audience
Who are they?
WIIFT?
Beliefs

Controlling Idea

Protagonist
Antagonist
Conflict



Creative techniques

- ☐ Limitations
- ☐ Details, facts, anecdotes
- ☐ Mystery Box
- ☐ Metaphors
- ☐ Cultural references
- ☐ Simplicity
- ☐ Show, don't tell
- ☐ Interact

TAKE IT WITH YOU

The Setting

- Period
- Location
- Duration
- Adjacent characters

The Setting helps us understand the Stakes later in the story

The Inciting Event

Introduce complication – put the plot into motion

The Pressure Point and The Stakes

- The lowest Arc point – with the highest Stakes
- What are you **risking**? What do you stand to lose or gain?
- How much **does it matter** to you? What will happen if you fail?
- Stakes can be both internal and external
- The Stakes are inextricably linked to the Controlling Idea

Dilemma

A dilemma is a **difficult** choice – a trade-off **between two evils, or between two blessings** – with **significant** consequences (if it's between good and bad, it's not really a difficult choice)

How to raise the Stakes: Define the Dilemma; Remember the Setting; Change the pace; Zoom in with details; Add a time limit; Make it personal for the nemesis; Make it bigger; Break the 4th wall

TAKE IT WITH YOU

Resolution and Change

Ask yourself:

- How was the Conflict resolved? Did the Resolution convey the Controlling Idea?
- What Change has the Protagonist undergone?
- What lesson did the Hero learn? What did the Hero discover about herself?
- What did that discovery compel the Hero to do? [through the Hero's actions, the audience recognizes the Change]

How it all connects

